

NAVIDAD BORICUA

Nochebuena en tu cocina

The Christmas Eve table: coquito to toast, perrito to carve, rice and beans to share, and coconut sweets for the night that runs long.

Authentic recipes · Bilingual · From the Ortiz kitchen

Hecho con corazón y sofrito · sofritostudio.com

Nochebuena

Puerto Rican Christmas starts on the 24th — Nochebuena — with family, music, and a table that is really a marathon. Coquito comes out early, pernil goes in the oven before dawn, and the rice and beans wait for nobody. This menu is the classic, timed so you can enjoy the night instead of guarding the kitchen.

Coquito — The Toast

Coquito — Authentic Puerto Rican Coconut Holiday Drink Recipe

Coquito · Puerto Rico's coconut eggnog — the holiday drink that replaces everything from November through January. Every family has a secret recipe.

Ingredients

- 2 cans (13.5 oz) coconut milk
- 1 can (14 oz) sweetened condensed milk
- 1 can (12 oz) evaporated milk
- 1 cup white rum
- 1 teaspoon vanilla extract
- 1 teaspoon ground cinnamon
- Pinch of ground nutmeg

Steps

1. Pour all ingredients into a blender: coconut milk, condensed milk, evaporated milk, rum, vanilla, cinnamon, and nutmeg.
2. Blend on high for 1-2 minutes until completely smooth and frothy.
3. Taste and adjust — add more cinnamon for warmth, more rum for kick, or more condensed milk for sweetness.
4. Pour into glass bottles or jars. Refrigerate for at least 4 hours (overnight is better) to let the flavors meld.
5. Serve ice cold over ice, dusted with a generous sprinkle of ground cinnamon on top.

Pernil Asado — The Centerpiece

Pernil Asado — Slow-Roasted Puerto Rican Pork Shoulder Recipe

Pernil · Slow-roasted pork shoulder with crispy skin and garlicky mojo criollo. The Nochebuena centerpiece.

Ingredients

- 1 bone-in pork shoulder (8-10 lbs)
- 8 cloves garlic, mashed into a paste
- 1/4 cup olive oil
- 2 tablespoons dried oregano
- 1 tablespoon black pepper
- 1 tablespoon salt
- 2 tablespoons white vinegar
- 1/4 cup sofrito

Steps

1. Score the pork skin in a crosshatch pattern with a sharp knife, cutting through the fat but not into the meat.
2. Make the mojo criollo: mash garlic with oregano, pepper, salt, vinegar, olive oil, and sofrito into a thick paste.
3. Rub the paste all over the pork, working it under the skin and into every crevice.
4. Cover tightly and refrigerate overnight (at least 8 hours) to let the marinade penetrate.
5. Roast at 375°F for about 4 hours, basting every hour, until the internal temperature reaches 185°F and the skin is crackling-crispy.
6. Let rest for 20 minutes before carving. The juices redistribute and the skin stays crisp.

Arroz con Gandules

Arroz con Gandules — Authentic Puerto Rican Rice and Pigeon Peas Recipe

Arroz Con Gandules · Puerto Rico's national dish — rice, pigeon peas, and sofrito. The one-pot meal every boricua makes for holidays.

Ingredients

- 2 cups long-grain rice
- 1 can (15 oz) gandules (pigeon peas), drained
- 1/4 cup sofrito
- 2 tablespoons vegetable oil
- 1 packet sazón con culantro y achiote
- 1 teaspoon ground cumin
- 2.5 cups chicken broth
- 1/2 cup manzanilla olives with pimento
- Salt to taste

Steps

1. Heat oil in a large caldero or heavy pot over medium heat. Add sofrito and sauté for 2 minutes until fragrant.
2. Add drained gandules and cook for 3 minutes, stirring occasionally.
3. Stir in sazón and cumin. Cook for 1 minute to bloom the spices.
4. Add rice and stir to coat every grain in the sofrito mixture.
5. Pour in chicken broth, add olives, and bring to a boil. Stir once, then reduce heat to low.
6. Cover tightly and cook for 25 minutes without lifting the lid. Fluff with a fork before serving.

Tembleque

Tembleque — Puerto Rican Coconut Milk Pudding Recipe

Tembleque · A coconut milk pudding that literally jiggles — the holiday dessert on every Puerto Rican Christmas table.

Ingredients

- 2 cans (13.5 oz) coconut milk
- 1/2 cup cornstarch
- 1/2 cup sugar
- 1/4 teaspoon salt
- Ground cinnamon for dusting

Steps

1. In a small bowl, whisk the cornstarch with 1/2 cup of the coconut milk until completely smooth with no lumps. Set aside.
2. Pour the remaining coconut milk into a medium saucepan. Add the sugar and salt. Heat over medium, stirring occasionally, until it reaches a gentle simmer.
3. Whisk the cornstarch mixture one more time, then slowly pour it into the simmering coconut milk, whisking constantly.
4. Continue cooking and whisking for 3-5 minutes until the mixture thickens to a pudding consistency. It should coat the back of a spoon.
5. Pour into a mold, bundt pan, or individual cups. Let cool to room temperature, then cover and refrigerate for at least 4 hours until fully set.
6. To unmold, run a knife around the edges and invert onto a plate. Dust generously with ground cinnamon before serving.

Besitos de Coco

Besitos de Coco — Authentic Puerto Rican Coconut Macaroons Recipe

Besitos De Coco · Coconut macaroons shaped into little kisses — chewy, sweet, and impossibly simple.

Ingredients

- 3 cups sweetened shredded coconut
- 2 eggs
- 1/3 cup sugar
- 1 teaspoon vanilla extract
- Pinch of salt

Steps

1. Mix coconut, eggs, sugar, vanilla, and salt until combined.
2. Scoop tablespoon-sized mounds onto a parchment-lined baking sheet.
3. Bake at 325°F for 12-15 minutes until edges are golden.
4. Cool completely on the baking sheet.

The Nochebuena Timeline

Days ahead: make the coquito (it only gets better) and the besitos. The night before: marinate the pernil, refrigerate covered. Christmas Eve morning: start the pernil low and slow. Mid-afternoon: rice and beans. Early evening: carve the pernil, set the table. When the coquito runs out, that is how you know it worked.